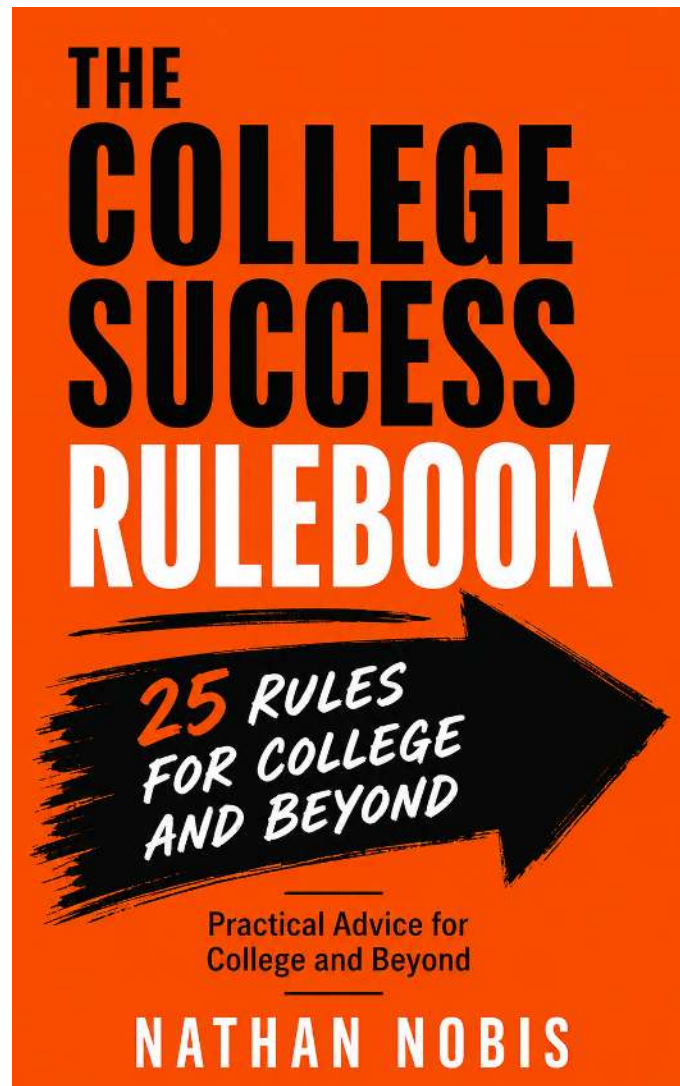


THE COLLEGE SUCCESS RULEBOOK: PRACTICAL ADVICE FOR COLLEGE AND BEYOND



Nathan Nobis
Morehouse College



The College Success Rulebook:

Practical Advice for College and Beyond

Nathan Nobis

This text is disseminated via the Open Education Resource (OER) LibreTexts Project (<https://LibreTexts.org>) and like the thousands of other texts available within this powerful platform, it is freely available for reading, printing, and "consuming."

The LibreTexts mission is to bring together students, faculty, and scholars in a collaborative effort to provide an accessible, and comprehensive platform that empowers our community to develop, curate, adapt, and adopt openly licensed resources and technologies; through these efforts we can reduce the financial burden born from traditional educational resource costs, ensuring education is more accessible for students and communities worldwide.

Most, but not all, pages in the library have licenses that may allow individuals to make changes, save, and print this book. Carefully consult the applicable license(s) before pursuing such effects. Instructors can adopt existing LibreTexts texts or Remix them to quickly build course-specific resources to meet the needs of their students. Unlike traditional textbooks, LibreTexts' web based origins allow powerful integration of advanced features and new technologies to support learning.



LibreTexts is the adaptable, user-friendly non-profit open education resource platform that educators trust for creating, customizing, and sharing accessible, interactive textbooks, adaptive homework, and ancillary materials. We collaborate with individuals and organizations to champion open education initiatives, support institutional publishing programs, drive curriculum development projects, and more.

The LibreTexts libraries are Powered by [NICE CXone Expert](#) and was supported by the Department of Education Open Textbook Pilot Project, the California Education Learning Lab, the UC Davis Office of the Provost, the UC Davis Library, the California State University Affordable Learning Solutions Program, and Merlot. This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Grant No. 1246120, 1525057, and 1413739.

Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation nor the US Department of Education.

Have questions or comments? For information about adoptions or adaptations contact info@LibreTexts.org or visit our main website at <https://LibreTexts.org>.

The LibreTexts name, logo, and book covers are trademarked by LibreTexts, Inc. (a 501(c)(3) not-for-profit organization) and protected against unauthorized use.

This text was compiled on 08/14/2026

- [InfoPage](#) by [Delmar Larsen](#) is licensed [Public Domain](#).

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Licensing

Introduction

25 Rules for Success

Research Note

Index

Glossary

Detailed Licensing

Detailed Licensing

Licensing LicensingEdit Update titlecancel

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

Introduction IntroductionEdit Update titlecancel

College gives you an unusual amount of freedom. Nobody is likely to follow you around making sure you go to class, do the reading, start your paper early, check your email, or study for an exam. That freedom is one of the good things about college. It also means that much more of the responsibility for your education now belongs to you.

This guide is written for college students, especially students who are new to college and still figuring out what college expects of them. Some of what follows may seem obvious to you. Other things may be things nobody has ever explicitly told you. Professors often assume that students already know how to be successful college students, even though many of these expectations and habits have to be learned.

The advice here comes from years of working with college students and seeing both what helps students succeed and what unnecessarily gets in their way. The goal isn't to give you another collection of rules to follow. It's to make some of the unwritten rules of college explicit—and help you develop what can be called “habits of excellence.”

Eventually, these behaviors can become part of how you think about yourself. Instead of “I have to study tonight,” the thought becomes closer to “I am a serious student, so of course I prepare.” You are becoming a budding scholar: someone capable of learning difficult things, thinking independently, and taking responsibility for doing good work.

And some of this will be difficult. That's normal. Difficulty is not, by itself, evidence that you are bad at college, that you do not belong here, or that a course is unfair. Often it means that you are doing something you do not yet know how to do. College should involve hard work: you are learning hard things and developing your skills at doing hard things. You are earning a degree, not simply spending time in school.

The expectations below—these “rules”—are demanding because college students are capable of meeting demanding expectations. They are also practical: these habits make it easier to learn, earn good grades, become someone professors and classmates can rely on, and prepare for whatever you want to do after college. You will not do all of them perfectly. Nobody does. The goal is to get better at them and, over time, make them yours.

This page titled [Introduction](#) is shared under a [CC BY 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Nathan Nobis](#).

25 Rules for Success 25 Rules for SuccessEdit Update titlecancel

1. Go to Class. Consistently.

This sounds obvious. And it is.

When you miss class, you miss explanations, examples, announcements, discussion, practice, and opportunities to ask questions. You also lose something harder to replace: the experience of working through ideas with the professor and other students.

Make attendance the default rather than a decision you reconsider every morning. “Do I feel like going today?” is not a useful question. Serious students go to class because that is part of what they do.

If you must miss class, find out what you missed. A classmate can often help. Do not assume that the professor is responsible for recreating the class for you.

2. Arrive On Time and Stay the Whole Class.

Being on time is a small behavior that says something larger: you planned ahead, you respect other people's time, and you can be relied upon.

Use the restroom beforehand. Charge your devices. Get food or coffee before class. Leave enough travel time. Emergencies happen, of course, but routinely arriving late or leaving early should not.

Imagine getting an internship or an entry-level job you really want. Regularly walking into important meetings late—or getting up and leaving halfway through—would not help your reputation. College is a good place to build habits that help you avoid that reputation.

3. Bring What You Need.

Come prepared: notebook, pen or pencil, assigned readings, a charged laptop if it is needed and permitted, and whatever else the course requires.

Preparation makes it easier to learn. If everything you need is already there, you can spend your attention learning instead of solving avoidable little problems.

4. Take Notes.

Listening can create the feeling that you understand something. Having to put an idea into your own words is a better test.

Take notes actively. Record important claims, distinctions, examples, arguments, questions, and things you do not understand. Your notes are not supposed to be a transcript of everything said in class; they should show your mind working on the material.

When practical, try taking notes by hand. It can encourage active processing and removes many of the distractions that come with having a screen in front of you.

There are many ways to take notes, so explore different approaches and experiment to find one that works well for you. Almost any thoughtful method is better than taking no notes at all.

Imagine again that dream internship or entry-level job. A big meeting runs long, so everyone agrees to finish it tomorrow. The next day, a supervisor asks you to review the details of the previous meeting in front of everyone. Are you better off with good notes to speak from or with no notes? Again, having notes is almost always better.

5. Focus During Class.

Your attention is valuable. Do not give it away for an hour to notifications, social media, shopping, games, watching videos or whatever else your phone would rather have you doing.

Being in the room while mentally somewhere else is not much better than being absent. Some professors ban phones because they know how difficult divided attention makes learning. Whether or not your professor imposes that rule, you can impose a useful rule on yourself: when class starts, be there in body and mind.

6. Do the Readings.

If a professor assigns something, assume there is a reason for it. Read it. You are not merely trying to find out what the reading says. You are training yourself to understand it.

AI summaries, TikToks, blogs, YouTube videos, and someone else's explanation can sometimes help you understand a difficult text. But they are supplements, not substitutes. If you routinely outsource the reading, you may finish assignments without developing your own ability to read difficult material—which is one of the abilities college is supposed to help you develop.

Always start by reading the assigned text. Then, if needed, use other resources to fill gaps in your understanding before class. Better yet, talk with classmates about the reading or bring your questions to the instructor's office hours.

7. Learn How to Read Actively.

Difficult reading often feels difficult because it is difficult. Do not immediately interpret that feeling as “I’m bad at this” or “I can’t understand this.”

Read with questions in mind:

What is the author trying to establish? Why?

What reasons are offered?

What concepts matter?

What do you disagree with?

What don't you understand? Mark up the text (underline, highlight, flag important sections, etc.), take notes, and afterward summarize the central ideas without looking at the text. Different academic disciplines often have their own approaches to reading, so look for guides for particular classes—for example, “How to read philosophy” or “How to read psychology.”

If you cannot explain the main idea or reconstruct the argument from a reading, go back. Many readings need to be read more than once. That's not failure; that's just what's involved in reading challenging material.

8. Follow Directions Carefully.

One frustrating way to lose points is to do substantial work but not do the work that was actually assigned.

Before starting, read the prompt carefully. Turn it into a checklist if that helps.

Before submitting, reread the prompt and ask:

Did I answer the question(s)?

Did I do every required part? Is the format correct?

Am I submitting the right file?

Feel free to reach out to your professor if you still have questions after reading and reflecting on the assignment instructions. But first check the instructions and syllabus carefully; the answer may already be there.

Start early enough that you can ask a question if something remains unclear. “I read the assignment and I’m unsure what this part means” is a useful question to ask your instructor. Discovering the problem an hour before the deadline leaves everyone fewer options.

9. Check the Syllabus Regularly.

The syllabus is the operating manual for the course. It usually tells you what is due, when it is due, how grading works, what materials you need, and what the course policies are.

Get in the habit of looking there before asking a routine question. Also make sure you are using the most recent version if the schedule has changed. Knowing how to find information for yourself is part of becoming an independent student.

10. Check Email and the Learning Management System (LMS) Every Day.

College gives you freedom, but freedom works much better when you keep yourself informed.

Professors communicate schedule changes, assignments, feedback, and other important information through email and the LMS (e.g., Canvas, Blackboard, Moodle, etc.). Make checking them a daily habit—ideally at roughly the same times each day— rather than something you remember to do when you suspect there might be a problem.

11. Read Feedback on Your Work.

A grade tells you how the work turned out. Feedback can tell you how to make the next piece of work better.

Read it. Then do something with it. If a professor tells you that your thesis is unclear, your evidence is weak, or your explanation needs development, look for that issue in the next assignment before you submit it.

Criticism of your work is not a judgment of your worth or your intelligence. In a demanding course, serious feedback is often a sign that your professor thinks you are capable of producing better work.

12. Ask Questions Early.

Confusion is normal, about many aspects of classes. But don't stay confused because you were afraid to ask about something: be bold and ask!

Ask questions while there is still time for the answer to help you. Do not wait until the night before the exam, after the deadline, or the final week of the semester.

Asking a good question is not evidence that you are unintelligent. Often it is evidence that you are paying attention closely enough to notice what you do not yet understand.

13. Use Office Hours.

Office hours are one of the strange bargains of college: you have regular access to people who have spent years becoming experts, and many students barely use it.

Go with a question, an idea, a draft, or something you want to understand better. You do not need to be failing. Office hours are for learning.

They are also how professors get to know you. Someday you may want a recommendation for an internship, graduate program, scholarship, or job. A professor can say much more about a student who has actually talked with them.

14. Manage Your Time.

Do not make your future self responsible for everything.

College work takes time, and students routinely underestimate how much. Put deadlines in a calendar. Break large assignments into smaller pieces. Decide in advance when you will do them. "I'll work on it sometime this week" is not much of a plan; "Tuesday from 3:00 to 4:30 I will draft the first two pages" is.

15. Submit Work On Time.

Deadlines are not unique to school. Applications close. Taxes are due. Employers and coworkers depend on other people finishing things when they said they would.

Professors also organize their work around deadlines, including setting aside time to grade yours. Treat deadlines as real.

If something serious happens, communicate early. Explain the situation clearly and ask respectfully what options are available. Silence usually makes a manageable problem harder.

16. Use Technology—and AI—Wisely.

Technology is useful when it increases what you can do. It is less useful when it replaces abilities you are supposed to be developing. Given that, here's a good rule:

| *anything you can't do for yourself, AI shouldn't do for you.*

If you use AI for tasks that you cannot do yourself, you may never learn how to do those tasks well. AI can therefore prevent you from developing the abilities and understanding your classes are supposed to cultivate: you may turn in assignments without developing yourself as much as you could have.

The point of college is not merely to produce assignments. Part of the product is you: a person who can read, write, reason, solve problems, and learn independently. Don't use AI in ways that make that person less capable.

Furthermore, AI makes mistakes, but you will not be able to realize that unless you are a person who really knows your stuff. Become that person.

17. Learn Basic Academic Technology Skills.

You should be able to create and format a document, upload and download files, find instructor comments, organize folders, name files sensibly, convert common file formats, and navigate your school's LMS.

These are not glamorous skills. Neither is knowing how to attach the correct document to an email. But being able to handle ordinary technology without someone rescuing you is part of academic and professional independence. Doing all of your coursework on a phone is usually not effective.

18. Improve Your Writing.

Writing is thinking that other people can inspect.

Clear writing usually requires rewriting. Organize your paragraphs. Make your main point clear. Explain what you mean. Give the reader the reasons or evidence they need. Then revise.

Very few people consistently produce excellent first drafts. Starting early is therefore not merely a timemanagement trick; it gives you the opportunity to turn an adequate first attempt into genuinely good work. Take advantage of campus resources, such as the writing center and writing tutors, if you need additional help with your writing.

Different academic disciplines often have their own conventions for writing, so look for guides for particular classes—for example, “How to write in history classes” or “How to write in business classes.”

19. Study Smarter, Not Just Longer.

Hours spent “studying” are not all equal. A familiar page can make you feel as though you know the material when what you really know is that you have seen the page before.

Make yourself retrieve information. Close the book and explain the idea. Quiz yourself or a classmate who quizzes you in return. Work practice problems. Use flashcards appropriately. Return to material over multiple days rather than trying to force everything into your head the night before the exam.

Study somewhere you can actually concentrate. And make studying routine. Two focused hours spread across several days will often teach you more than a panicked late-night marathon.

20. Use Campus Resources.

Independent does not mean alone.

Colleges provide tutoring, writing centers, librarians, research help, accessibility services, counseling, advising, and other academic support because capable people sometimes need information, coaching, feedback, or assistance.

Using a resource is not an admission that you do not belong in college. Knowing when to seek useful help is itself a form of competence.

21. Communicate Professionally.

People form judgments about whether they can rely on you partly from how you communicate.

Write clear and respectful emails. Use a respectful greeting. Say who you are and what course you are in when that is relevant. Explain what you need. Respond when a response is expected. If you will miss something important or have a serious problem, communicate promptly rather than disappearing. Look up guidance on “How to email a professor”; while you are at it, compare it with advice on “How to email an employer.”

You are practicing habits here that future supervisors, coworkers, clients, and colleagues will notice too.

22. Develop Your Own Ideas.

A good college education should eventually make you less dependent on other people telling you what to think.

Many assignments are not just asking, “Can you repeat what the professor said?” They are asking you to explain, evaluate, compare, argue, interpret, or defend a conclusion.

Take that invitation seriously. You are allowed to have your own ideas. You are also responsible for giving good reasons for them.

23. Cultivate Habits of Excellence.

The individual strategies in this guide matter. The larger goal is to stop experiencing them as a collection of rules that somebody else is making you follow.

Build routines that make the right action easier: a regular place and time to study, a daily email check, a weekly look at upcoming deadlines, a habit of reviewing feedback before beginning the next assignment. When possible, decide in advance what you will do instead of asking your tired, distracted future self to make a good decision in the moment.

Over time, these behaviors can become part of your identity: you show up. You prepare. You finish what you start. You ask when you don't understand. You can do difficult work. You can improve things after receiving criticism.

That is what I mean by habits of excellence. Excellence is not one heroic night of studying. It is a way of working

24. College Is Practice for Life Beyond College.

College matters partly because of what you learn in your courses. It also gives you years of practice becoming a person other people can trust with important things.

Reliability. Preparation. Focus. Judgment. Initiative. Clear communication. The ability to learn something difficult, respond to criticism, solve problems, and keep going when the first attempt does not work.

Those are not merely school behaviors. They are capacities that give you more options in life. The habits you build now can follow you long after anyone cares what grade you earned in a particular class.

25. Don't Do It All Alone

You will have bad weeks. You will procrastinate sometimes. You will misunderstand things, receive disappointing grades, forget something important, and occasionally discover that a strategy that worked before no longer works.

Do not turn one difficulty into a conclusion about who you are. Ask a better question: What should I do next?

And remember that doing things for yourself does not mean doing everything by yourself. If you are struggling to develop any of these habits or skills, ask for help. Professors, administrators, advisors, tutors, classmates, friends, and family can all be sources of guidance and support. Knowing when you need help— and seeking it out—is itself a habit of excellence, not a failure of independence. Many people at your college want you to succeed; give them the opportunity to help you do that.

College is supposed to stretch you. Treat difficulty as a reason to adjust your strategy, seek information, practice, ask for help, and keep working—not as automatic evidence that you cannot do it.

You are earning a degree. More importantly, you are developing yourself. Build habits worthy of the person you want to become.

This page titled [25 Rules for Success](#) is shared under a [CC BY 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Nathan Nobis](#).

Research Note Research NoteEdit Update titlecancel

This guide is written for students rather than as a review of educational psychology, but its presentation has been informed by research on adolescent and young adult motivation and learning.

In particular, this presentation emphasizes high expectations combined with respect and autonomy; the idea that difficulty can signal importance and growth rather than inability; identity-based motivation; students' sense of belonging; connecting academic work to personally meaningful purposes; and evidence based learning strategies such as practice testing and distributed practice.

Key influences include David Yeager's work on the “mentor mindset” and growth mindset; Daphna Oyserman's work on identity-based motivation; Edward Deci and Richard Ryan's self-determination theory; Gregory Walton and Geoffrey Cohen's work on belonging; Chris Hulleman and Judith Harackiewicz's work on utility value; and John Dunlosky and colleagues' review of effective learning techniques.

This page titled [Research Note](#) is shared under a [CC BY 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Nathan Nobis](#).

Detailed Licensing Detailed LicensingEdit Update titlecancel

Overview

Title: [The College Success Rulebook: Practical Advice for College and Beyond](#)

Webpages: 14

All licenses found:

- [CC BY 4.0](#): 71.4% (10 pages)
- [Public Domain](#): 21.4% (3 pages)
- [Undeclared](#): 7.1% (1 page)

By Page

- [The College Success Rulebook: Practical Advice for College and Beyond](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Front Matter](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [TitlePage](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [InfoPage](#) - [Public Domain](#)
 - [Table of Contents](#) - [Public Domain](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [Public Domain](#)
 - [Introduction](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [25 Rules for Success](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Research Note](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Back Matter](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Index](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Glossary](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)

Detailed Licensing Detailed LicensingEdit Update titlecancel

Overview

Title: [The College Success Rulebook: Practical Advice for College and Beyond](#)

Webpages: 14

All licenses found:

- [CC BY 4.0](#): 71.4% (10 pages)
- [Public Domain](#): 21.4% (3 pages)
- [Undeclared](#): 7.1% (1 page)

By Page

- [The College Success Rulebook: Practical Advice for College and Beyond](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Front Matter](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [TitlePage](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [InfoPage](#) - [Public Domain](#)
 - [Table of Contents](#) - [Public Domain](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [Public Domain](#)
 - [Introduction](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [25 Rules for Success](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Research Note](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Back Matter](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Index](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Glossary](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)